

Iran backs off threats to execute protesters

Government tries to make a distinction between them and ‘terrorists’

By **Abdi Latif Dahir and Sanam Mahoozi**
NEW YORK TIMES

Iran appeared to backpedal on previous threats to execute protesters, amid global condemnation and fears of US military action, even as the government continues a brutal crackdown after weeks of demonstrations.

Iran’s judiciary said on Thursday that it had not issued a death sentence for Erfan Soltani, 26, a protester whose execution had been widely reported as imminent and had drawn intense international attention. The comments were reported by Iran’s state broadcaster and published on social media.

As authorities forcibly try to suppress the protests, thousands of people have been killed so far — mostly civilians but also members of the security services, according to rights groups.

President Trump said Wednesday that he had been told the execution of protesters would not go ahead, and that the killing in Iran had stopped, without offering further details.

Yet analysts say that the Iranian government is also trying to make a distinction between ordinary protesters and those it calls rioters and terrorists, backed by foreign powers. That nuance of messaging, the analysts said, was intended to put pressure on citizens and dissuade them from protesting.

Iran’s chief justice, Gholam-Hossein Mohseni-Ejei, said on Thursday that the prosecution of “rioters” would be carried out swiftly, according to the state broadcaster. He added that individuals linked to “foreign intelligence services and their handlers,” and those who directed “rioters and

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Democrat finds common ground with MAHA on pesticides

By **Tal Kopan**
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — As activists and groups aligned with Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. celebrated a victory in a battle against pesticides this week, they had perhaps an unlikely person to thank: a Democrat from Maine.

“Make America Healthy Again,” or MAHA, has become largely synonymous with the Trump administration. It was coined by Kennedy as a result of his political alliance with President Trump and his tenure as health secretary has put its goals prominently at the center of the Republican administration’s health policy.

But it was Democratic Representative Chellie Pingree who emerged as its most consequential champion in Congress, leading the effort to remove a provision from a government funding bill that could have given pesticides protection from new scrutiny by regulators and courts. Last week, the House passed the funding bill without the language MAHA had been opposing for months. The Senate did the same on Thursday, sending the law to Trump’s desk.

Pingree fought the provision independently of

PESTICIDES, Page A5

A BIG HONOR



MATTHEW J. LEE/GLOBE STAFF

With all-time Bruins great Bobby Orr on hand, former Boston star Zdeno Chara was cheered Thursday night as he had his number retired. Chara, who played for Boston for 14 seasons, was the 13th Bruin to have his number retired. “I’m speechless,” he said after the ceremony. **C1.**

The T expects to find itself in a **\$560 million** budget hole in the fiscal year starting July 1, double the current deficit.

It anticipates the pit will deepen to **\$732 million** the following year.

Huge deficit could pop T’s balloon

Projected to worsen in future; agency looks to Beacon Hill

By **Jaime Moore-Carrillo**
GLOBE STAFF

The MBTA, as of late, has basked in a strong but unfamiliar public optimism, powered by long overdue spending on major repairs that have led to a sustained period of improved service.

But now echoes of the bad old days are threatening to haunt commuters again, and it’s again down to the long-beleaguered agency’s Achilles’ heel: money.

On Thursday, the MBTA dis-

closed that barring a huge infusion of new cash from the Legislature, it will have a massive budget deficit of some \$560 million for the fiscal year that begins in July. That’s double the current deficit, according to agency projections shared at a public meeting. Moreover, it’s projected to get even worse the following year, growing to as much as \$732 million, which would rival the financial shortfalls of the agency’s more infamous eras of late.

“This is bad,” Brian Kane,

the longtime head of the agency’s public oversight body, said in reference to the 2028 forecasts. “I’m not sure what else to say. I think I’ve run out of superlatives.”

While at this point this may seem more a problem on paper than on the rails and roads, it was precisely the T’s chronic inability to secure adequate funding that left the system in such bad shape for so long.

And few commuters need to be reminded of just how dis-

MBTA, Page A6



DAVID L. RYAN/ GLOBE STAFF

The T has been hailed for its improvements, but money woes continue to be a problem.

‘If you want something that lasts, something that’s handmade, then neon is most definitely the way to go.’

DAVE WALLER, *Neon Williams shop*

Feeling a warm glow for signs of those times



MATTHEW J. LEE (TOP), BARRY CHIN (ABOVE), /GLOBE STAFF



ARAM BOGHOSIAN FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE/FILE

Neon is still around if you know where to look. Cheapo Records and the Somerville Theatre remain committed to it, while the Shell sign on Memorial Drive is powered by LEDs.

Neon has faded over the years, replaced by LEDs, but a local diehard is keeping the classic stuff shining

By **Spencer Buell**
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — There was a heyday for neon, and this isn’t it.

Sure, signs made of twisted, gas-filled glass that buzz and radiate warm light can still be found here. Some, like the decades-old marquee at the Somerville Theatre in Davis Square, have survived, becoming landmarks.

But these days, if lit-up letters in a shop window or on the wall of a nightclub catch your eye, odds are they’re made with light-emitting diodes, or LEDs, not the real thing. It’s a fate befalling even the most storied neon signs in cities everywhere.

Enter Dave Waller, who makes and fixes glass-and-gas neon signs by hand and fervently believes that even in an era of AI slop, fast fashion, and

cheap knockoffs, a resurgence in the popularity of neon is underway.

“If you want a quick fix, then buy an LED sign,” said Waller, who since 2019 has owned a neon shop in Somerville that is one of the last of its kind. “If you want something that lasts, something that’s handmade, then neon is most definitely the way to go.”

Last year, he bought another neon shop in New York City. Soon, he plans to double the size of his Somerville workshop, called Neon Williams, so it can take on bigger projects, and more of them.

His handiwork, and that of his team of six, is all over New England: the George’s Coney Island sign depicting a hand gripping a hot dog in Worcester, and the letters spelling out Kelly’s Din-

NEON, Page A7

Decline of Saks reflects changes

High-end retail struggling; local stores stay open

By **Dana Gerber**
GLOBE STAFF

The number of mannequins rivaled the number of customers in New England’s sole full-fledged Saks Fifth Avenue store in the Prudential Center on a recent weekday afternoon.

While the outpost is far from the luxury retailer’s namesake address in New York City, the turmoil at corporate headquarters that landed Saks in bankruptcy this week seemed to lurk among the many “sale” signs spread across two floors in the Back Bay tower. Under bright lights, employees stationed near a sunglasses display and in a Dior nook scrolled on their phones. A blond shopper looked at an overcoat, glanced at the \$1,298 price tag, and kept moving.

“Whenever I come here, not many people are around here,” said Leere Kang, a

SAKS, Page A7

The Venezuelan opposition leader, Maria Corina Machado, said she presented her Nobel Peace Prize medal to President Trump, bringing scorn in Norway. A3.

President Trump said he might use the Insurrection Act to crack down on the protests in Minneapolis. A2.

Vineyard Wind is pushing back against the Trump administration’s stop-work order issued late last year, and filed for an injunction. B5.



Matter of degrees

Friday: Seasonable. High 32-37. Low 26-31.
Saturday: A little rain/snow. High 36-41. Low 31-36.
Sunrise: 7:10 Sunset: 4:38
Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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Suggested retail price
\$4.00

